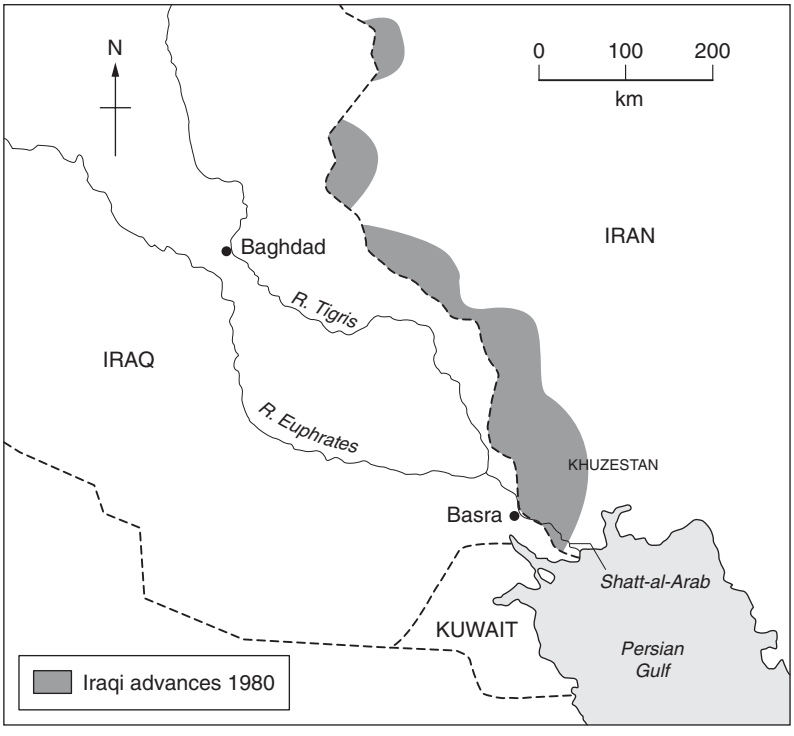


This map shows some of the main areas of fighting in the Iran–Iraq War.

Within two years Iran had recaptured all of its land and succeeded in cutting Iraq off from its sea ports. The war became prolonged and calls for a ceasefire came to nothing largely because Iran said it would not settle for anything less than the overthrow of Saddam's regime. When Iran stated that its target was Baghdad, the Iraqi capital, the Iraqi forces became more united in their determination to defend their country. By 1984, the two sides had become bogged down in trench warfare along the 1500-km border. It was similar, in this way, to the First World War fighting in the trenches except that sand, not mud, was what bogged the soldiers down.

Foreign involvement in the war

Key question
Which foreign powers became involved in the war?

Another reason why the war lasted for so long was because of foreign involvement. Most of the Arab states supported Iraq. They feared that Iranian forces might cross the border to liberate the Iraqi Shiites and establish an Iraqi state loyal to Khomeini. They were opposed to the spread of Iran's revolutionary, Shiite version of an Islamic state. Although Khomeini appealed to *all* Muslims, the war certainly widened the Sunni/Shiite divisions.

In the Arab Gulf states which were closest to Iran (Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain and the United Arab Emirates – see the map on page 116), there was little support for the Islamic Revolution except among the Shiite minority. The war also revived the historic animosity between Arabs and Persians. Saudi Arabia and the smaller oil-rich states in the Gulf, together with Egypt and Jordan, supported Iraq and supplied money and arms. Jordan